

Mike and I looked at each other, shrugged our shoulders and shook our heads in unison.

Avoiding One of Life's Biggest Traps

“Well, you boys had better start thinking. You're staring at one of life's biggest lessons. If you learn the lesson, you'll enjoy a life of great freedom and security. If you don't learn the lesson, you'll wind up like Mrs. Martin and most of the people playing softball in this park. They work very hard, for little money, clinging to the illusion of job security, looking forward to a three-week vacation each year and a skimpy pension after forty-five years of work. If that excites you, I'll give you a raise to 25 cents an hour.”

“But these are good hard-working people. Are you making fun of them?” I demanded.

A smile came over rich dad's face.

“Mrs. Martin is like a mother to me. I would never be that cruel. I may sound cruel because I'm doing my best to point something out to the two of you. I want to expand your point of view so you can see something. Something most people never have the benefit of seeing because their vision is too narrow. Most people never see the trap they are in.”

Mike and I sat there uncertain of his message. He sounded cruel, yet we could sense he was desperately wanting us to know something.

With a smile, rich dad said, “Doesn't that 25 cents an hour sound good? Doesn't it make your heart beat a little faster.”

I shook my head “no,” but it really did. Twenty five cents an hour would be big bucks to me.

“OK, I'll pay you a dollar an hour,” rich dad said, with a sly grin.

Now my heart was beginning to race. My brain was screaming,

An

“Take it. Take it.” I could not believe what I was hearing. Still, I said nothing.

“OK, \$2 an hour.”

My little 9-year-old brain and heart nearly exploded. After all, it was 1956 and being paid \$2 an hour would have made me the richest kid in the world. I couldn't imagine earning that kind of money. I wanted to say “yes.” I wanted the deal. I could see a new bicycle, new baseball glove, and adoration of my friends when I flashed some cash. On top of that, Jimmy and his rich friends could never call me poor again. But somehow my mouth stayed silent.

Maybe my brain had overheated and blown a fuse. But deep down, I badly wanted that \$2 an hour.

The ice cream had melted and was running down my hand. The ice-